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Decision Journal

Think Better. Decide Better. Learn Faster.

By Ricky Recalcati

Introduction

Every decision teaches you something.

The problem is that most people only remember the outcome. They forget what they were thinking when they made it.

A Decision Journal helps separate good decisions from lucky outcomes and bad outcomes from bad thinking.

Over time you'll begin to notice patterns:

- recurring mistakes
- emotional decisions
- hidden biases
- better judgement

Professional investors, CEOs and elite performers have used decision journals for decades.

This workbook gives you a practical system you can return to again and again.

How To Use This Journal

Complete a new entry before making any meaningful decision.

Examples include:

- accepting a new job
- investing money
- hiring someone
- changing careers
- buying a house
- starting a business
- making an important personal decision

Once the outcome becomes clear, return to the journal and complete the review.

Your goal isn't perfection.

Your goal is improving your thinking.

Decision Checklist

Before every important decision ask yourself:

1. What decision am I making?

2. Why does it matter?

3. What outcome do I want?

4. What assumptions am I making?

5. What evidence supports them?

6. What evidence challenges them?

7. What would make me change my mind?

Common Thinking Traps

Watch for these biases:

- ☐ Confirmation bias
- ☐ Overconfidence
- ☐ Fear of missing out
- ☐ Sunk cost fallacy
- ☐ Recency bias
- ☐ Anchoring
- ☐ Groupthink
- ☐ Emotional decision-making

Reflection:

Which of these affects you most often?

Decision Scorecard

Rate yourself before deciding.

Confidence

Evidence Quality

Emotional Control

Time Available

Understanding of Risks

Confidence

Decision Template

Decision Number _____

Date

The Decision

Why This Matters

Why This Matters

My Desired Outcome

My Desired Outcome

Options Considered

Option 1

Pros

Cons

Option 2

Pros

Cons

Option 3

Pros

Cons

Which option am I choosing?

Why?

Risks

What could go wrong?

How likely are these?

☐ Low

☐ Medium

☐ High

How could I reduce these risks?

Assumptions

I'm assuming that...

How certain am I?

☐ Low

☐ Medium

☐ High

Worst-Case Scenario

If everything went wrong...

What would happen?

How would I recover?

Would I survive it?

☐ Yes

☐ No

Confidence Check

Complete the sentences.

The strongest reason this decision succeeds is...

The strongest reason it fails is...

Future Review

Review this decision after:

- ☐ 1 Month
- ☐ 3 Months
- ☐ 6 Months
- ☐ 12 Months

Outcome Review

Date Reviewed

What happened?

Did the outcome match my expectations?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ Partly
- ☐ No

Lessons Learned

What did I get right?

What did I miss?

What would I do differently?

Decision Rating

Rate this decision.

Preparation ★★★★★

Logic ★★★★★

Execution ★★★★★

Outcome ★★★★★

Overall ★★★★★

Blank Decision Templates

The remainder of the workbook should contain six identical full-page decision templates using the same structure:

- Decision
- Context
- Options
- Risks
- Assumptions
- Final Choice
- Confidence Rating
- Future Review
- Lessons Learned

Each template should start on a new page and leave generous writing space.

Blank Decision Template 1

Use this page before making a meaningful decision. Return to it when the outcome becomes clear.

Decision

Context

Options

Risks

Assumptions

Final Choice

Confidence Rating

Future Review

Lessons Learned

Blank Decision Template 2

Use this page before making a meaningful decision. Return to it when the outcome becomes clear.

Decision

Context

Options

Risks

Assumptions

Final Choice

Confidence Rating

Future Review

Lessons Learned

Blank Decision Template 3

Use this page before making a meaningful decision. Return to it when the outcome becomes clear.

Decision

Context

Options

Risks

Assumptions

Final Choice

Confidence Rating

Future Review

Lessons Learned

Blank Decision Template 4

Use this page before making a meaningful decision. Return to it when the outcome becomes clear.

Decision

Context

Options

Risks

Assumptions

Final Choice

Confidence Rating

Future Review

Lessons Learned

Blank Decision Template 5

Use this page before making a meaningful decision. Return to it when the outcome becomes clear.

Decision

Context

Options

Risks

Assumptions

Final Choice

Confidence Rating

Future Review

Lessons Learned

Blank Decision Template 6

Use this page before making a meaningful decision. Return to it when the outcome becomes clear.

Decision

Context

Options

Risks

Assumptions

Final Choice

Confidence Rating

Future Review

Lessons Learned